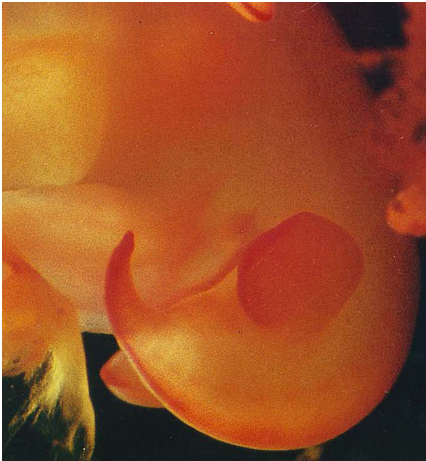




YOU ARE **7 WEEKS AND 3 DAYS**

228 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

At this stage, the embryo's "tail," shown curving up on the left, is starting to disappear. The somites of this area of the musculoskeletal system will eventually form the four fused bones of your baby's coccyx—the lowest part of the spine.

“ Even if you're happy about having a baby, it's natural to have mixed emotions at times. ”

At this early stage of pregnancy, changing hormone levels may cause mood swings and unexpected emotional responses. Your emotions may fluctuate—one minute you're laughing and the next you're irritable and yelling, or crying. Sometimes things that have never been a problem, such as hearing a particular piece of music or seeing an ad, might make you cry, or you may snap at your loved ones over something trivial. You might be confused that at a time when you should be happy, you often feel tense and tearful. Be reassured that this is a normal and temporary part of pregnancy and try not to be too hard on yourself.

These changing moods are caused mainly by pregnancy hormones, which is something out of your control. They are the same hormones that cause the symptoms of PMS—rapid mood swings, crying, and irritability—that you might have experienced before.

Be kind to yourself during these down times and do what works best for you, whether it's taking time out to be alone or sharing your feelings with others.

One in 10 pregnant women have symptoms of depression. If you are concerned that you might be depressed, seek the advice and help of your doctor. Having a supportive partner can make all the difference to managing mood swings during pregnancy. As a partner, all you can do is be as patient, and understanding as you can. Until the mood passes, which it will, just bide your time, bite your tongue, and give your partner a hug.